

PRD — Chronos Place: Dating for People Living With & Beyond Chronic Conditions

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Overview

Chronos Place is an enterprise-grade dating and connection platform for adults living with, managing, or beyond chronic health conditions such as HIV, diabetes, cancer, epilepsy and autoimmune disease. It removes the disclosure burden from dating: members decide exactly who learns about their health and when, on a platform engineered so health data cannot leak.

Vision: a diagnosis never decides who gets to be loved.

Item	Detail
Product	Chronos Place (development title)
Document	Product Requirements Document, v0.1 draft
Launch market	South Africa, then SADC, then global
Platforms	iOS and Android apps; web for admin, moderation and partner portals
Delivery standard	Production-deployable at general availability (GA), not a throwaway MVP
Data classification	Health data is special personal information under POPIA and GDPR Article 9

Problem and opportunity

People with chronic conditions face a painful choice on mainstream apps: disclose early and risk rejection, or disclose late and risk accusations of deception. Chronos Place makes disclosure a controlled, respected part of the product instead of a hidden landmine.

- **Stigma:** HIV and other conditions still carry stigma, and disclosure can lead to rejection, harassment, outing or violence.
- **Disclosure burden:** members repeat the same emotionally costly conversation with every new match.
- **Trust deficit:** mainstream apps have leaked health data before, notably Grindr's 2018 sharing of HIV status with analytics vendors.
- **Market gap:** existing niche apps focus mainly on HIV and STIs, feel dated, and serve Africa poorly.
- **Scale in the launch market:** South Africa has one of the largest populations living with HIV globally, plus a growing diabetes burden, so demand is concentrated where Chronos Place launches.

Chronos Place's opportunity is to be the trusted, broad, well-designed home for this community, with Africa as the anchor market.

Target users and personas

Primary users are adults 18+ living with or beyond a chronic condition; allies open to dating them join once the community is established, not at launch. The personas below are illustrative and must be validated through user research.

Persona	Profile	Core need	Biggest fear
Thandi, 29, Johannesburg	Living with HIV, undetectable, career-focused	Date without explaining her status to every match	Being outed to colleagues or family
Sipho, 41, Durban	Type 1 diabetes since childhood, divorced	Partner who understands insulin, highs and lows	Being seen as a burden
Ayesha, 35, Cape Town	Breast cancer survivor, in remission	Rebuild confidence and intimacy after treatment	Pity instead of attraction
Daniel, 52, Pretoria	Rheumatoid arthritis, limited dexterity	Easy, accessible app that doesn't tire his hands	Apps that feel built for 22-year-olds

Persona	Profile	Core need	Biggest fear
Lerato, 31, Soweto (post-launch ally)	No condition; her late brother had epilepsy	Meet someone kind and date without stigma	Saying the wrong thing

Internal users: trust and safety moderators, support agents, compliance officers, and partner organisations such as NGOs and clinics.

Goals, non-goals and success metrics

Chronos Place succeeds when members form real connections and zero health data is ever exposed. Targets below are proposed for the first 12 months after GA and need validation.

Goals

- Help members form meaningful connections with disclosure on their own terms.
- Protect health data to a standard that can pass ISO 27001 and SOC 2 Type II audits.
- Build a respectful, safe community with fast, trained moderation.
- Reach sustainable revenue through subscriptions and partnerships, never by selling data.

Non-goals

- Chronos Place is not a medical service and gives no diagnosis or treatment advice.
- Chronos Place does not verify diagnoses with medical records at launch.
- Chronos Place does not sell, share or monetise health data for advertising, ever.
- Chronos Place is not a hookup-first app; product decisions favour relationships and community.

Metric	Target (12 months)	Why it matters
Health-data security incidents	0	Existential trust metric
Verified profile rate	80% of active members	Reduces scams and fake profiles
Match-to-conversation rate	40%	Shows matching quality

Metric	Target (12 months)	Why it matters
Conversations reaching 10+ messages	25% of conversations	Proxy for meaningful connection
30-day retention	35%	Product-market fit signal
Median time to action a safety report	Under 2 hours; under 15 minutes for high severity	Member safety
Paid conversion	6% of monthly active users	Commercial sustainability
Net Promoter Score	40+	Community trust and word of mouth

Product principles

These principles break ties when requirements conflict; privacy wins over growth every time.

1. **Member controls disclosure.** No health information is ever shown without an explicit, revocable member choice.
2. **Private by architecture, not policy.** Leaks must be structurally impossible, not merely forbidden.
3. **Person first, condition second.** Profiles lead with personality; the condition is context, never the headline.
4. **Safety is a feature.** Verification, reporting and moderation are designed and funded like core product.
5. **Warm, not clinical.** It should feel like a great dating app, never a hospital portal.
6. **Accessible to everyone.** Design for low vision, limited dexterity, fatigue, low data and older devices.
7. **Never monetise vulnerability.** No dark patterns, no paywalling safety, no selling data.

Functional requirements

GA ships every P0 requirement below; P1 follows within six months. Priorities are editable from the dropdowns.

Epic	Requirement	Priority
Onboarding	Sign-up by phone or email with one-time PIN; 18+ age gate	P0 — GA
Onboarding	Selfie liveness verification with a visible verified badge	P0 — GA
Onboarding	Privacy walkthrough shown before any health data is requested	P0 — GA
Profile	Up to 6 photos, prompts, interests and relationship intent	P0 — GA
Profile	Optional health profile: conditions, status (living with, in remission, survivor) and own-words note, stored only in the Health Vault	P0 — GA
Profile	Private mode: profile visible only to people the member has liked	P1 — GA + 6 months
Discovery	Feed filtered by distance, age and intent; condition-aware preferences only when the member opts in	P0 — GA
Discovery	Like, pass and mutual match	P0 — GA
Discovery	Daily curated picks from the ranking service	P1 — GA + 6 months
Messaging	End-to-end encrypted chat with text, photos and voice notes	P0 — GA
Messaging	Consent-gated disclosure card that shares health details inside a chat	P0 — GA
Messaging	In-app video calls, available only after a match	P1 — GA + 6 months
Safety	Block, unmatched and report from any profile or message	P0 — GA
Privacy	Discreet app icon and name, PIN or biometric lock, quick-exit gesture	P0 — GA
Privacy	Download my data; delete account with full erasure within 30 days	P0 — GA

Epic	Requirement	Priority
Community	Moderated interest groups and events, such as newly diagnosed or Type 1 dating	P1 — GA + 6 months
Community	Content hub from vetted partner NGOs and clinicians	P2 — Later
Monetisation	Subscriptions and one-off purchases through app stores	P0 — GA
Operations	Admin console for moderation, support, compliance and audit review	P0 — GA

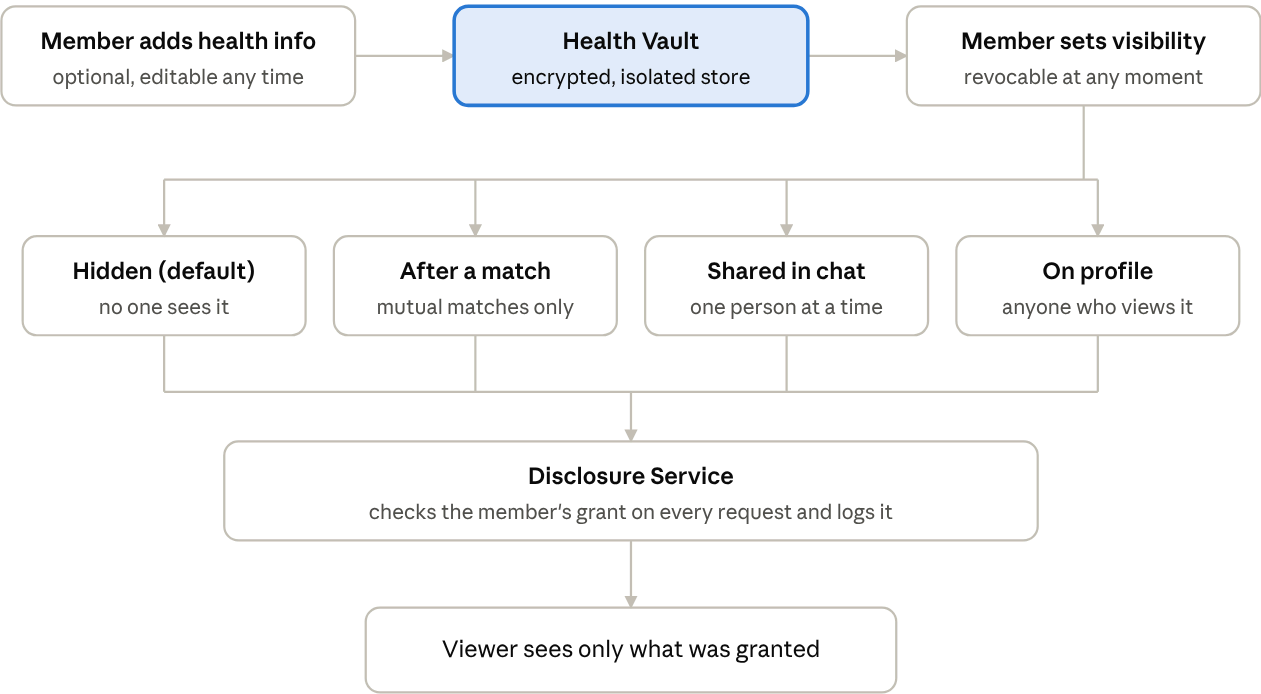
Every feature must meet the disclosure, safety and privacy requirements in the sections that follow.

Health disclosure and consent system

Disclosure is Chronos Place's core feature: health details default to hidden and appear only through explicit grants the member controls and can revoke.

Health details stay hidden until the member chooses to share

Every reveal is written to the audit log; revoking a grant ends access at once



disclosure flow · 4 visibility levels, 1 consent check

No service except the Disclosure Service can read the Health Vault, so every reveal passes one consent check and one audit record.

Visibility level	Who sees health details	Typical use
Hidden (default)	Nobody	Members who want to disclose in person, or never
After a match	Mutual matches only	Members who want interest established first
Shared in chat	One chosen person, via a disclosure card	Members who disclose case by case
On profile	Anyone who views the profile	Members who want to filter for acceptance up front

Rules

1. **Explicit processing consent.** Onboarding captures separate, specific consent to process health data, recorded with policy version and timestamp; withdrawing it deletes Vault data.
2. **Granular, revocable grants.** Each grant is stored per viewer or audience; revoking takes effect immediately, including cached copies on devices.
3. **Disclosure card preview.** Before sharing in chat, the member sees exactly what the recipient will see; the recipient must tap to open it.
4. **Screen protection.** Screens showing health details block screenshots on Android and blur plus notify on iOS, where full blocking is impossible.
5. **Filter fairness.** Only members sharing their own condition can use condition-aware filters, which stops people browsing purely to find statuses.
6. **Inference protection.** Feeds, filters and counts must not let anyone deduce a hidden condition; small result sets are suppressed below a minimum threshold.
7. **No leakage paths.** Health data never appears in push notifications, emails, logs, analytics events, crash reports or support tickets.
8. **Member visibility log.** Members can see who has viewed their health details and when.

Trust and safety

Chronos Place's members are unusually exposed to outing, blackmail, scams and fetishisation, so safety is staffed and engineered as a core system, not an add-on.

Threat	Requirement
Fake profiles and bots	Mandatory selfie liveness check before messaging; phone verification; device fingerprinting to block repeat offenders
Romance and financial scams	Detection of scam patterns such as money requests, off-platform links and crypto talk; in-chat warnings; fast-track review
Outing and blackmail	Screenshot protection, disclosure audit trail, dedicated high-severity report category, 15-minute response target
Fetishisation and harassment	Toxicity detection on text and images; member-controlled message filters; permanent bans for condition-based abuse

Threat	Requirement
Health misinformation	Block sale or promotion of fake cures and unproven treatments; link to vetted partner content
Members in distress	Keyword-triggered, non-intrusive signposting to crisis and support lines; trained moderators with escalation paths
Offline meeting risk	Date-safety check-ins, share-my-date with a trusted contact, safety tips before first meetings

Moderation operations

- **Layered review:** automated classifiers first, then human moderators, with a severity-based queue.
- **Trained team:** moderators trained on HIV and chronic illness stigma, trauma-informed practice and POPIA handling of special personal information.
- **Moderator privacy:** moderators see health data only when a report requires it, with access logged and time-limited.
- **Moderator wellbeing:** rotation, counselling access and exposure limits for moderators handling distressing content.
- **Transparency:** members are told the outcome of their reports; a published enforcement report is issued each year.
- **Law enforcement requests:** a documented process requiring valid legal process, legal review and member notification where lawful.

Privacy, security and compliance

Chronos Place must be POPIA-compliant at launch and GDPR-ready before any EU expansion, with ISO 27001 and SOC 2 Type II targeted within 18 months of GA. Specific legal positions must be confirmed with a South African privacy lawyer.

Regulatory requirements

Framework	Applies when	Key obligations
POPIA (South Africa)	From launch	Special personal information rules for health and sex life; explicit consent; Information Officer registered with the Information Regulator; breach notification; prior authorisation check for cross-border transfers
GDPR (EU and UK)	EU or UK expansion	Article 9 special category data; Data Protection Impact Assessment; EU representative; data subject rights within one month
US state health privacy laws, such as Washington's My Health My Data Act	US expansion	Separate consent for consumer health data; no sale without signed authorisation
Kenya and Nigeria data protection acts	SADC and wider African expansion	Local registration, sensitive-data consent, residency checks
App Store and Google Play policies	From launch	Accurate privacy labels, health data disclosures, account deletion in-app

Security controls

- **Encryption:** TLS 1.3 in transit; AES-256 at rest; field-level envelope encryption for Health Vault data with keys in a hardware security module.
- **Key management:** per-member data keys, automatic rotation, and crypto-shredding so deleting a key makes that member's health data unrecoverable, including in backups.
- **Zero-trust access:** single sign-on with phishing-resistant MFA for staff; no standing production access; just-in-time, approved, logged access.
- **Immutable audit logs:** every Health Vault read and every admin action written to tamper-evident storage retained per legal advice.
- **Data minimisation:** collect only what a feature needs; approximate location only, never exact coordinates shown to others.

- **Third-party controls:** no advertising SDKs; analytics self-hosted; every vendor processing personal data signs an operator agreement and passes security review.
- **Secure development:** threat modelling for every epic, static and dependency scanning in CI, annual external penetration tests, and a public bug bounty after GA.
- **Incident response:** a documented and rehearsed plan meeting POPIA and GDPR notification duties, with member communication templates prepared in advance.

Member data rights

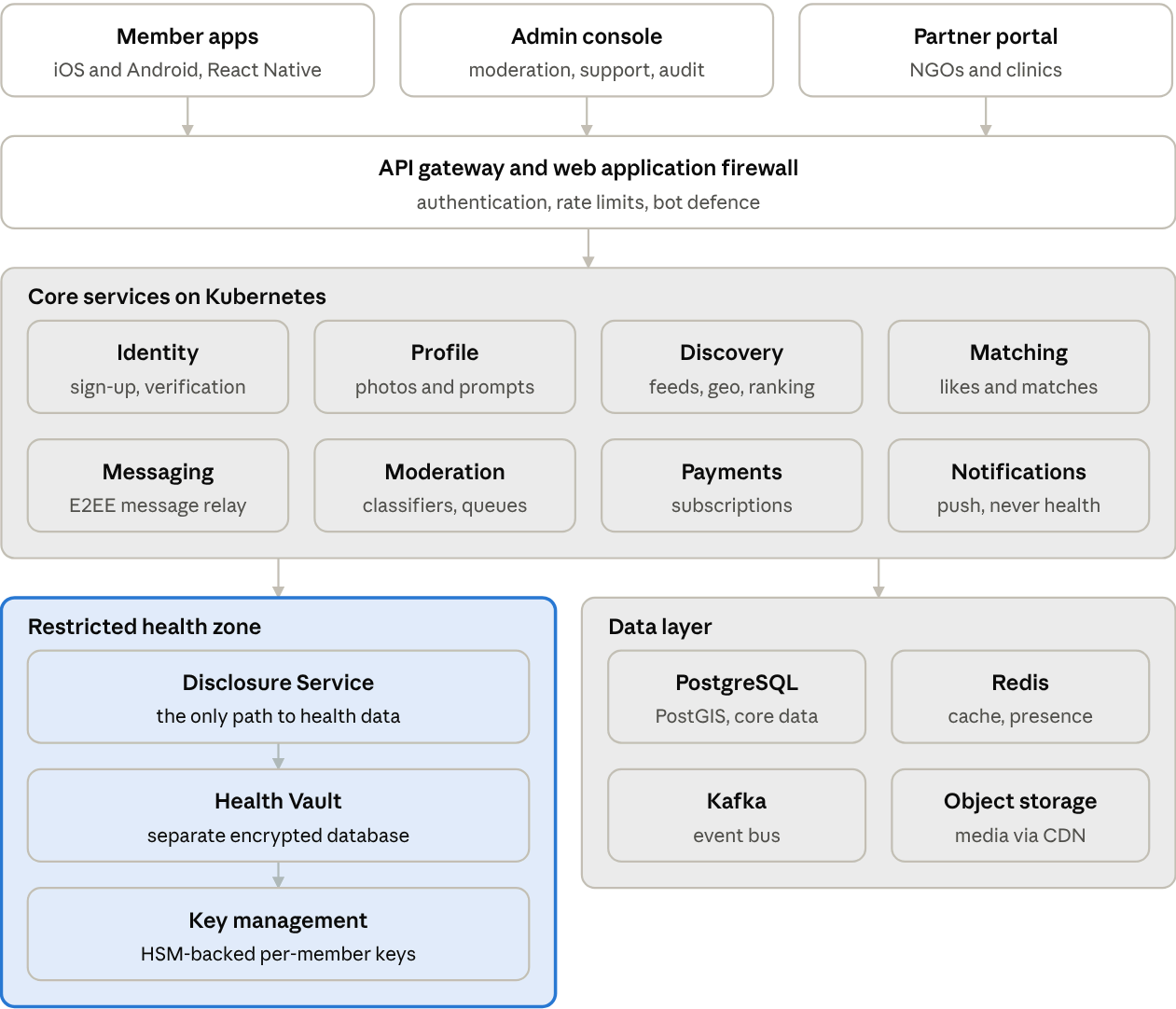
Members can view, export, correct and delete their data in-app. Account deletion erases profile data within 30 days and crypto-shreds Health Vault data immediately, except records the law requires Chronos Place to keep.

System architecture

Chronos Place runs as domain-based microservices on Kubernetes in South Africa, with health data isolated in a separate cloud account that only the Disclosure Service can call.

Health data sits in a walled-off zone that only one service can reach

Target architecture at GA, hosted in AWS af-south-1 (Cape Town)



system architecture · clients, gateway, core services, restricted zone, data layer

Services talk through the gateway and the Kafka event bus; none except the Disclosure Service holds credentials for the restricted zone.

Layer	Technology choice	Notes
Mobile apps	React Native with TypeScript	One codebase; native modules for camera, liveness, screen protection

Layer	Technology choice	Notes
Web consoles	React with Next.js	Admin, moderation and partner portals behind staff single sign-on
API	NestJS (TypeScript) or Go services; GraphQL for apps, gRPC between services	Contract-first APIs, versioned
Gateway and edge	AWS API Gateway or Kong, AWS WAF, CloudFront CDN	Rate limiting and bot defence at the edge
Compute	Amazon EKS across three availability zones	Autoscaling, service mesh with mutual TLS
Core data	Amazon Aurora PostgreSQL with PostGIS	Profiles, matches, geo queries
Health Vault	Separate Aurora cluster in its own AWS account	Field-level encryption, no network path except from Disclosure Service
Keys	AWS KMS with CloudHSM	Per-member keys, rotation, crypto-shredding
Cache and presence	Amazon ElastiCache for Redis	Feeds, sessions, rate limits
Events	Amazon MSK (Kafka)	Decouples services; health events never published
Messaging	Signal Protocol end-to-end encryption over WebSockets	Server stores only encrypted payloads
Video calls	WebRTC via LiveKit, self-hosted	Keeps call metadata in-region
Media	Amazon S3 with CloudFront, on-upload image moderation	Metadata such as GPS stripped from photos
Search and ranking	OpenSearch plus a ranking service	Precomputed feeds for fast discovery
Analytics	Self-hosted PostHog and a de-identified warehouse	No health data, no third-party ad SDKs
Observability	OpenTelemetry, Grafana, Sentry (self-hosted)	Health data scrubbed before logging

Layer	Technology choice	Notes
Infrastructure as code and CI/CD	Terraform, GitHub Actions, Argo CD, Expo EAS	Every change reviewed, scanned and reproducible
External services	Smile ID or Onfido for liveness; FCM and APNs for push; RevenueCat for billing	Vendors never receive health data

Data model and classification

Every field is classified before it is built; Restricted data lives only in the Health Vault and is linked to the member through a pseudonymous vault ID, never the account ID.

Class	Examples	Where stored	Controls
Restricted	Conditions, status, own-words health note, disclosure grants, health-view log	Health Vault	Field-level encryption, per-member keys, Disclosure Service only, full audit
Confidential	Messages, verification selfies, exact location, payment tokens	Encrypted stores per service	Encrypted payloads, short retention, strict role access
Internal	Profile text, photos, preferences, likes, matches	Core PostgreSQL and S3	Encryption at rest, role-based access
Public	Marketing pages, partner content	CMS and CDN	Standard controls

Core entities

Entity	Key fields	Class
Account	account ID, phone, email, verification status, created date	Confidential
Profile	account ID, display name, age, photos, prompts, intent, approximate area	Internal

Entity	Key fields	Class
Preference	account ID, distance, age range, intent, condition-aware filter flag	Internal
Like and Match	from ID, to ID, type, timestamp, status	Internal
Conversation	conversation ID, member IDs, encrypted message references	Confidential
Report	reporter, subject, category, severity, evidence references, outcome	Confidential
Consent record	account ID, consent type, policy version, granted or withdrawn, timestamp	Confidential
Health profile	vault ID, conditions, status, note, visibility level	Restricted
Disclosure grant	vault ID, viewer ID or audience, scope, granted and revoked timestamps	Restricted
Health access log	vault ID, accessor, purpose, timestamp	Restricted

The mapping from account ID to vault ID is itself held inside the restricted zone, so a breach of the core database reveals no health information.

Non-functional requirements

The platform targets 99.9% availability at GA and must scale to 1 million registered members without re-architecture. Figures are proposed targets for engineering to validate.

Area	Requirement
Availability	99.9% monthly for member-facing APIs; 99.95% for messaging and the Disclosure Service
Latency	API p95 under 300 ms in South Africa; feed load under 1 second; message delivery under 500 ms p95
Scale	1 million registered and 150,000 daily active members, with 10x burst headroom on messaging

Area	Requirement
Disaster recovery	Recovery point objective 5 minutes, recovery time objective 1 hour; in-country backups, restore drills every quarter
Data residency	Primary data in South Africa; cross-border transfers only after legal sign-off
Device support	iOS 16+ and Android 9+; usable on 2 GB RAM phones
Low data	Lite mode with compressed images; core flows under 5 MB a session; resilient on 3G
Localisation	English at launch; isiZulu, isiXhosa, Afrikaans and Sesotho by GA + 6 months; right-to-left ready
Observability	Tracing across all services; alerting on error budgets; health data never in logs
Maintainability	80% automated test coverage on core services; zero-downtime deploys; feature flags for every release

Design, content and accessibility

Chronos Place must feel like a warm, modern dating app and meet WCAG 2.2 AA from day one, because many members live with vision, dexterity or fatigue challenges.

Visual and brand direction

- Warm, optimistic and adult; no medical imagery, red ribbons or clinical blues as defaults.
- Profiles lead with photos, personality and prompts; health details sit in a discreet, clearly labelled area.
- Neutral app icon and name option so the app is not identifiable on a lock screen or home screen.
- A design system in Figma with tokens shared with code, covering light and dark themes.

Accessibility requirements

- Text scales to 200% without loss of content; minimum 4.5:1 contrast for text.
- Touch targets at least 44 by 44 points; no gestures that require precise swipes, with button alternatives for every swipe.
- Full screen reader support on VoiceOver and TalkBack, including the disclosure card and chat.
- Reduced motion setting honoured; no flashing content, protecting members with photosensitive epilepsy.
- Voice notes auto-transcribed so deaf and hard-of-hearing members can take part.
- Accessibility testing with disabled members before every major release.

Language and content

- Person-first, stigma-free language reviewed with community partners, for example "living with HIV", never "infected".
- Condition list co-created with patient organisations, with a free-text option and no forced labels.
- Plain-language privacy explanations at every point where health data is involved.
- An editorial style guide covering tone, terminology and how to write about bodies, treatment and intimacy.

Monetisation and partnerships

Chronos Place earns through member subscriptions and ethical partnerships; safety and privacy features are free for everyone and data is never sold.

Tier	Includes	Price (to validate)
Free	Verification, full disclosure controls, all safety tools, daily like limit, messaging with matches	Free
Chronos Place Plus	Unlimited likes, see who liked you, advanced filters, private mode, travel mode	About R149 a month
Chronos Place Premium	Plus features, priority placement, read receipts, video calls, message before matching	About R299 a month

Partnership revenue and reach

- **NGOs and patient organisations:** co-branded community groups and events; sponsored free Premium for members referred by partners.
- **Health and wellness brands:** clearly labelled, vetted sponsorship of content hubs, never targeted using health data.
- **Employers and medical schemes:** possible later channel for wellbeing programmes, subject to strict privacy review.

Pricing ethics

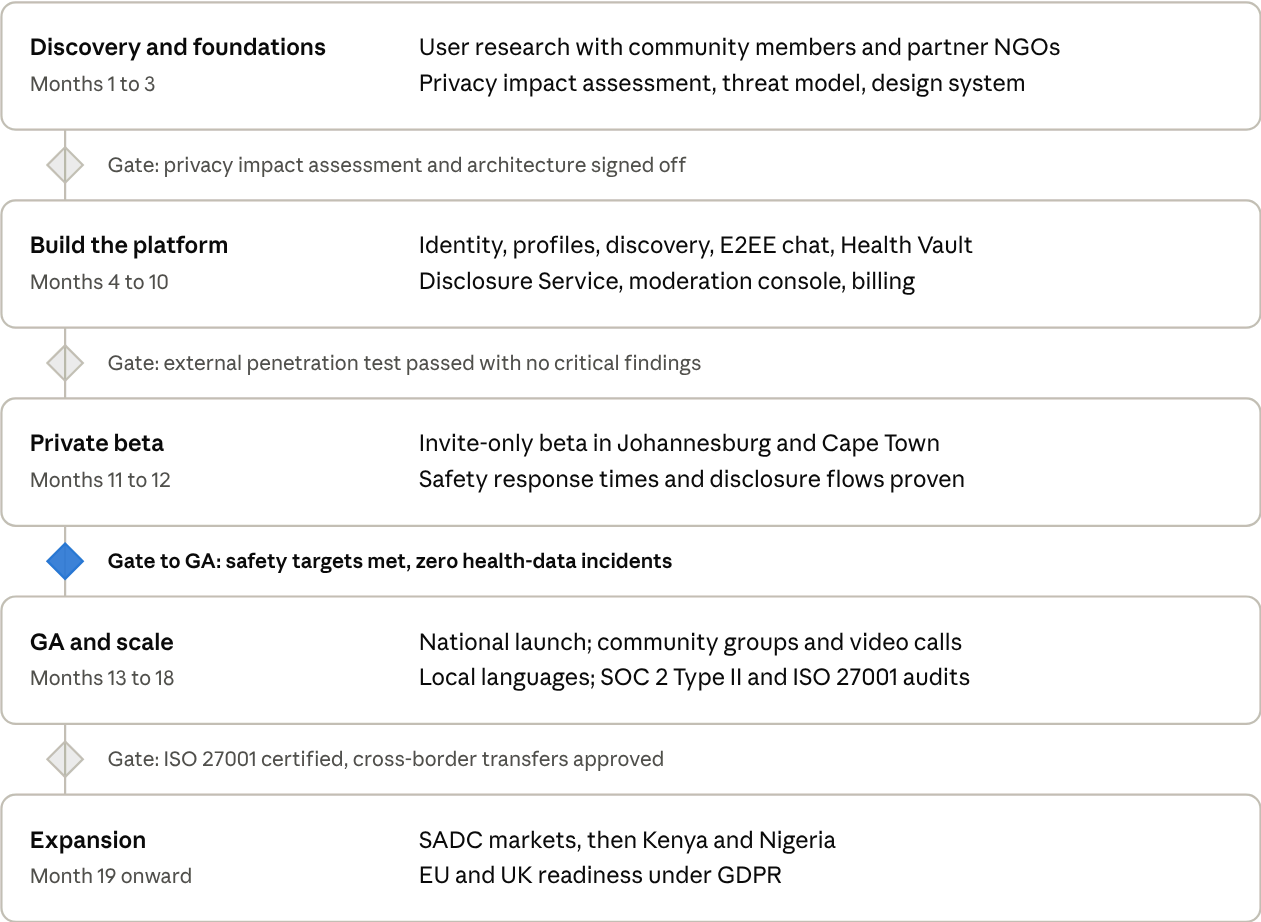
- No paywalls on safety, reporting, verification or privacy controls.
- Clear, one-tap cancellation and no manipulative renewal flows.
- Regional pricing for lower-income markets across SADC.

Release plan and roadmap

Chronos Place reaches general availability in about 13 months, but only after a gated private beta proves safety and privacy in real use. Timings are proposed and depend on team size.

General availability follows a gated private beta, about month 13

Proposed phases; no phase starts until its gate criteria are met



roadmap · 5 phases, 4 gates

Each gate is a hard stop: missing criteria delay the next phase rather than being waived.

Indicative team for the build phase

Role	Headcount
Product manager and product designer	1 each
Mobile engineers (React Native)	3
Backend and platform engineers	5
Security engineer	1
QA and test automation engineer	2

Role	Headcount
Data and ML engineer (ranking, moderation)	1
Trust and safety lead, then moderators from beta	1, growing
Privacy and compliance officer (Information Officer)	1

Risks and mitigations

A health-data breach is the one risk that could end the company, so it carries the most controls and the most budget.

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Health data breach or leak	Medium	Critical	Restricted zone, crypto-shredding, no third-party SDKs, pen tests, bug bounty, cyber insurance
Regulatory action under POPIA	Low	High	Information Officer, impact assessment before build, legal review of every data flow
Members outed or blackmailed by other members	Medium	Critical	Screen protection, disclosure audit trail, rapid-response safety team, law enforcement liaison
Scammers targeting vulnerable members	High	High	Mandatory liveness, scam detection, in-chat warnings, member education
Cold start: too few members in an area	High	High	City-by-city launch, partner NGO referrals, community events, broad condition list; allies added once established
Stigma-driven harassment or bad press	Medium	High	Clear community guidelines, zero tolerance, community advisory board, crisis communications plan

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
App store rejection over health data	Low	Medium	Early review of store health-data policies, accurate privacy labels
High moderation cost	Medium	Medium	Automation first, severity routing, partner-trained volunteer ambassadors for community spaces
Condition labels feel excluding or clinical	Medium	Medium	Co-design the condition list with patient organisations; free-text option

Open questions and next steps

These decisions shape scope and cost and should be settled during the discovery phase.

Open questions

- Decided: a broad open list at launch, co-designed with patient organisations, with a free-text option. Options weighed were a focused set such as HIV, diabetes and cancer survivorship, or a broad open list.
- Decided: allies without a condition join after the community is established, not at launch.
- Decided: Chronos Place is a new standalone company, and it is the responsible party for all member data.
- Decided: build to published laws and regulations (POPIA and related rules) from day one; formal legal review, Information Regulator questions and any licences are settled before real member data is processed in the private beta, and before public launch.
- Decided: chat is built in-house on the open-source Signal libraries; moderation relies on member reports that forward decrypted messages.
- Which NGOs and patient organisations become founding partners and advisory board members?
- Decided: Chronos Place is the development title; the final product name stays open pending trademark, domain and community testing.

Next steps

- ☐ Appoint a privacy lawyer and draft the privacy impact assessment

- ☐ Run 20 to 40 interviews with people living with chronic conditions and with partner organisations
- ☐ Validate pricing and willingness to pay in the South African market
- ☐ Produce clickable Figma prototypes of onboarding and the disclosure flow for testing
- ☐ Complete a threat model and security architecture review
- ☐ Build a budget and hiring plan for the build phase